

Interview Experience – NatWest

Hi everyone, I am **Badrinath S (2022503017)** and I am glad to share my NatWest interview experience.

Round 1 – Online Assessment (On Campus)

The initial screening test was conducted on **SHL**. It tested:

- Basic English grammar and comprehension
- Logical reasoning (including visual reasoning)
- SQL (MCQs)
- 2 coding questions

The first coding question was very easy:

Print even numbers first and odd numbers next.

Here, there was a small trick. If you use `i % 2 == 1` for odd numbers, it will fail for negative integers.

The second question was a **medium-level greedy problem**. I always use **Java** in coding interviews since many companies prefer it (as most backends are in Spring Boot). For this question, I created another class called **Pair** with three variables so that managing comparisons after using `Collections.sort` became easier.

My tip for this round:

- Do not waste time reading the entire long paragraph. Many companies add lengthy text to consume your time. Instead, first read the input format and required output. That will give you a clear idea of what the problem is about.
- Once you understand the requirement, try to map the problem to a suitable data structure.
- Be strong in **basics**, such as how to take input using the Scanner class.
- If your code does not work immediately, don't panic. Use **console print statements** to debug and trace the error.
- Above all, stay **honest** throughout your placement season. That's the best way to prepare better and shine.
- Prepare aptitude through mock test in SHL portal.

I got shortlisted along with 23 others for the next round.

Round 2 – Technical + HR (Combined, 45 minutes)

Both interviewers were kind and introduced themselves at the beginning. They started by asking about the **Pre-Placement Talk** that happened just before the interviews. They also asked me if I knew about NatWest earlier. I replied that, as a cricket fanatic, I knew that NatWest had once sponsored the England Cricket Team.

Next, they moved on to my **resume**. They asked about my projects and were impressed that they solved real-world problems. They said they liked my approach and mentioned that it aligned well with the company's vision. At that point, I was confident that I had a good chance of receiving the offer.

Then came the **DSA round**. They gave me a simple array question involving a HashSet. I explained my approach, and the interviewer suggested storing the index instead of the element. I explained that even then, the time complexity would remain **O(N)**. The interviewer agreed and was satisfied.

After that, they asked a **SQL query** to find the **third highest mark**. Initially, I wrote a nested query. The interviewer pointed out that its complexity could be reduced. I then suggested using ORDER BY DESC and picking the third record (I forgot the word "OFFSET," but the interviewer mentioned it himself and said my approach was correct).

They also asked a few **basic ML questions**—such as *What is supervised learning?* and *What is an activation function?*—based on my resume, which mentioned ML.

Behavioral Round

Next, they moved toward **behavioral questions**.

They asked me about my view on **learning new technologies**. I replied that I am always open to learning anything necessary to solve a client's problem. However, I also added that I am not the type of person who upskills without a clear need, as I prefer to focus my efforts where they bring value.

They then asked me about my **integrity**. One question was: *"What would you do if an ethically wrong person asked you to do something in the bank that is profitable for both the company and the bank?"*

I answered that I value **honesty above all**, as it is crucial for long-term success, even if shortcuts may give temporary relief. I also mentioned that if I had to reject an unethical request, I would do so firmly but with **kindness**, ensuring I handle the situation with respect.

Another question was about **AI**. They asked me how I would use it. I responded that I would not allow AI to hamper my own thinking capabilities. Instead, I would use it to perform tasks where I already know the logical approach, thereby improving **speed and execution**.

The interviewers were impressed with my responses. At the end, they asked if I had any questions. I politely said I didn't have any. They told me they enjoyed the conversation, wished me all the best, and I left the room with a sense of **gratitude**.

My Tips

1. Always include **ML** in your resume if you have worked on it. Interviewers value that highly.
 2. Do not panic; stay calm and honest.
 3. Never over-exaggerate your projects. Interviewers are more impressed when you explain your projects truthfully and confidently. Explain your projects in the perspective of how they would solve a real life problem.
 4. **Resume is the starting point:** The flow of the interview was driven by my resume. Be ready to explain every project you include and link it to solving real-world problems.
 5. **Explain your thought process:** In coding questions, the interviewer often looks at *how* you approach the problem rather than just the final solution.
 6. **SQL efficiency matters:** Knowing both a straightforward and an optimized approach shows maturity.
 7. **Behavioral questions test alignment with values:** Integrity, honesty, and adaptability were tested more than technical brilliance. Companies want people they can trust in sensitive domains like banking.
 8. **AI and emerging tech:** Instead of exaggerating, give a balanced view. Show openness to use new technologies while maintaining human reasoning.
 9. **Confidence > perfection:** Even when I forgot the keyword `OFFSET`, I handled it calmly. That mattered more than knowing every detail.
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Finally I got the offer along with 8 other candidates. Felt very relieved and was at peace after so much grind.

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